

ST 01: Introduction to Theology

Course Overview and Quick Reference

Morning Star Regional Seminary, Barrackpore BTh First-Year Course, Academic Year 2026-27

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THE COURSE IN ONE LINE

A problem-based introduction in which every lecture opens with a real theological question, and the whole course moves toward one goal: forming a responsible theologian for the Indian Church.

THE SIX QUESTIONS (the goals)

1. What is theology?
2. Why do theology?
3. How is theology done?
4. Who has authority in theology?
5. How has theology developed through history?
6. How do I become a responsible theologian today?

Question 6 is the destination. It is seeded in Lecture 5 and returns in every unit.

THE HIDDEN SPINE

The four precepts of Lonergan run through the course: be attentive, be intelligent, be reasonable, be responsible. They govern, in turn, the sources, history, method, and the final call to responsibility. The shape of the course is also its goal.

THE SIX UNITS

Unit	Lectures	Question it answers	Driving problem that opens it
I. Discovering Theology	1-5	Why do theology?	Can a priest preach without doing theology?

Unit	Lectures	Question it answers	Driving problem that opens it
II. The Nature of Theology	6-10	What is theology?	Why did Jesus never write a theology book?
III. The Sources of Theology	11-16	Who has authority?	Why are there hundreds of theologians if truth is one?
IV. The History of Theology	17-22	How has it developed?	Why does every age produce a different theology?
V. The Methods of Theology	23-29	How is it done?	Is theology information or method?
VI. Doing Theology Today	30-35	How to be responsible?	Can AI do theology?

Unit V, the methods, is the heart, built on the six models of Bevans. Orthodox theology keeps a dedicated lecture in it. Unit VI ends with the Theology Manifesto.

WHAT THE STUDENT WILL BE ABLE TO DO

By the end, every student can:

1. Define theology and say why it matters.
2. Explain how faith, reason, and revelation relate.
3. Name and use the sources of theology, and say who holds authority.
4. Tell the story of theology as the questions each age tried to answer.
5. Recognise the methods and the six models of contextual theology, and apply one to an Indian situation.
6. Articulate and defend a personal commitment to becoming a responsible theologian.
7. Own a working vocabulary of theological terms for life.

HOW EACH CLASS RUNS

10 minutes opening problem, 15 minutes teaching, 10 minutes discussion, 5 minutes reflection, 5 minutes assignment. Three students carry each reading as summariser, critic, and responder. The professor moderates.

DAILY READING

Eight to twelve pages, never more, drawn mostly from sources already held: Ormerod, Müller, the uploaded manual, Amaladoss, Segundo, and Gutierrez, with open-access Church documents and a few short pieces to source. Every reading carries a driving question and a journal prompt.

ASSESSMENT (no sit-down exam)

Component	Weight
Theological Journal	20%
Cumulative Glossary	10%
Parish-Priest Interview	10%
Theological Autobiography	15%
Mini Research Paper	20%
Theology Manifesto (capstone)	15%
Participation	10%

The Manifesto, written and spoken with a question round, replaces the exam. It measures Question 6 and safeguards the vocabulary. Sized to roughly two to two and a half ECTS.

CORE TERMS THE STUDENT WILL OWN

theologia, *fides quaerens intellectum*, revelation, *locus theologicus*, Tradition, Magisterium, *sensus fidelium*, hermeneutics, praxis, the hermeneutic circle, inculturation, contextualisation, the four precepts of Lonergan, the six models of Bevans, the preferential option for the poor, apophatic theology, *aggiornamento*, synodality.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Theology is not a set of truths to memorise. It is a way of thinking and living. This course gives the student the vocabulary, the methods, and the questions, and asks him to commit, by the last day, to becoming the kind of theologian the Church and the poor of India need.

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